Lesson 27: Infants: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 8.1: Discussion; 8.2: Listening-How Every Child Can Thrive by Five; 8.3: Reading-Mirror Stage; 16.6: Chapter 6 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

This lesson starts the chapter "Infants". You will discuss how children's brains develop, watch a TED talk by seven-year-old Molly Wright, "How Every Child Can Thrive by Five", and read a short academic text, "Mirror Stage", about when babies recognize themselves in a mirror. You will practise finding the central idea of a text and the evidence for it, a key skill for your psychology reading, and you will notice how writers report what researchers said, which prepares you for Lesson 28 (reported speech).

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Understand the main points and the numbers in a short talk about early brain development.
- Identify the central idea of an academic text and choose the quotation that best supports it.
- Describe how a theory changed over time and why other researchers disagreed with it.
- Recognize reporting verbs such as *show*, *propose* and *claim* in an academic text.
- Give and support your opinion about child development and technology.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
infant	a baby; a very young child	Lacan proposed that the mirror stage was part of an infant's development from 6 to 18 months.
toddler	a young child who has just learned to walk	… when infants and toddlers start recognizing their reflections in the mirror.
thrive	to grow, develop and do well	How Every Child Can Thrive by Five
neural connection	a link between nerve cells in the brain	It can create up to one million neural connections every second.
serve and return	the name scientists use for the back-and-forth contact between a child and an adult; Molly says it means "connect, talk and play with us"	Scientists call it serve and return.
hardwired	natural, present from birth, not learned	Kids are hardwired to seek out meaningful connections.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
empathy	the ability to understand and share another person's feelings	Copycat games build imagination and empathy.
reflection	the image of yourself that you see in a mirror	Human infants and chimpanzees both seem to recognize their reflection in a mirror.
identity	your sense of who you are	... the mirror stage's importance in identity formation
phenomenon (plural: phenomena)	something that happens and that people can observe and study	"The mirror stage is a phenomenon to which I assign [two values]."
a turning point	a moment when an important change happens	It marks a decisive turning point in the mental development of the child.
notion	an idea or a belief	Many other psychologists disagreed with the notion that ...
abstract	based on general ideas, not on real things that you can see or test	It had become so abstract by the 1950s that it was untestable.
central idea	the most important idea of a whole text (also called the main idea)	Which of the following statements best summarizes a central idea of the text?

Rules and explanations

How to work through this lesson

1. **Discussion:** think about the two questions before you watch (Practice 1).
2. **Listening first:** watch the talk without the transcript and answer Exercise 1. Only then read the transcript (at the end of your lesson material) to check your answers and find the words you missed.
3. **Reading:** read "Mirror Stage" in your lesson material and answer Exercise 2.

Before you watch

- The speaker, Molly Wright, is seven years old. On stage with her are Ari, a baby, and his dad, Amarjot, Molly's neighbor. They show an "experiment" with the game peekaboo.
- The questions ask about a number, a list of five things, a definition and a feeling. Listen for these.

Reading questions: central idea and evidence

- **Part A** asks for the *central idea*: the idea of the whole text, not one detail. Check each option: Is it in the text? Does it cover the whole text or only one paragraph?
- **Part B** asks for *evidence*: the quotation that best supports your Part A answer.

- **"The evolution of a concept"** means how an idea changed over time. Look for the time expressions in paragraph 2: *In 1936 ...*, *By the early 1950s ....*

Notice: how the reading reports research

"Mirror Stage" reports the ideas of several psychologists. Writers often use a **reporting verb** (a verb that introduces what someone said, wrote or found) + a *that*-clause (a part of the sentence that begins with *that* and has its own subject and verb):

- *Research has shown that ... they do not begin to recognize that the images in the mirror are reflections of their own bodies until the age of about 15 to 18 months.* (paragraph 1)
- *In 1936, psychologist Jacques Lacan proposed that the mirror stage was part of an infant's development from 6 to 18 months.* (paragraph 2)

Paragraph 3 also has **direct speech**, Lacan's exact words in quotation marks: *In 1953, Lacan wrote, "The mirror stage is a phenomenon ...".* In Lesson 28 you will find all the reporting verbs in this reading and learn the rules of reported speech.

Practice

1. Discussion (before you watch). Answer the questions based on your experience and opinion. Say your answers aloud and record them on your phone (1 to 2 minutes for each question), or discuss them with your tutor (see "Speak with your tutor").

1. What can help children's brain develop? How can parents help children's brains develop?
2. Can technology be beneficial for children? How? Why not?

2. Exercise 1: Listening comprehension. Watch the TED talk "How Every Child Can Thrive by Five" by Molly Wright (link in "Watch online"; about 7 minutes). Watch it first without the transcript. Choose the best answer.

1. By roughly 7 years old, the child's brain is _____ of an adult brain.
    - a) 30%
    - b) 50%
    - c) 75%
    - d) 90%
2. Which of the following is NOT one of the five ways adults can help children thrive?
    - a) Connecting
    - b) Talking
    - c) Playing
    - d) Technology
    - e) A healthy environment
    - f) Community
3. What does serve and return mean?

- a) Connect, talk, and play
- b) Throwing a ball and returning a ball
- c) Building vocabulary
- d) Playing peek-a-boo

4. According to the video, how do children feel when they lack connection?
    - a) Lonely
    - b) Confusion and stress
    - c) Lost
    - d) Trauma

3. Exercise 2: Reading comprehension. Read "Mirror Stage" in your lesson material (five paragraphs). Then answer the questions.

1. PART A: Which of the following statements best summarizes a central idea of the text?
    - a) The human brain is wired to recognize faces everywhere, even in inanimate objects.
    - b) Recognizing one's own face, as well as the faces of others, is crucial to forming a healthy identity.
    - c) Mirror stage describes the period in which infants begin recognizing their reflection, though its significance in identity development has been debated.
    - d) Mirror stage is the phenomenon in which two or more close individuals subconsciously mimic each other's expressions, actions, and/or gestures.
2. PART B: Which of the following quotes best supports the answer to Part A?
    - a) "...children are fascinated with images of themselves and others in mirrors...." (Paragraph 1)
    - b) "The 'mirror stage' refers to the point in time when infants and toddlers start recognizing their reflections in the mirror.... In psychology, there has been a debate about the mirror stage's importance in identity formation." (Paragraph 1)
    - c) "Lacan felt that understanding and processing one's reflection was a key part in the development of identity." (Paragraph 2)
    - d) "...human infants typically become very interested and devote much time and effort to exploring the connections between their bodies and their images." (Paragraph 4)
3. Which of the following best describes the evolution of Jacques Lacan's concept of the mirror stage?
    - a) Lacan changes the ages of the infantile mirror stage from 15-18 months to 6-18 months, allowing for a larger age range when babies can recognize their reflections.
    - b) Lacan calls the mirror stage as a phenomenon but later labels it as a general part of normal human (and chimpanzee) development.
    - c) Lacan's theory becomes more abstract, the concept taking on a more philosophical tone than a scientific one.
    - d) Lacan alters his concept so that it is not considered just a small period of an infant's life, but an essential and lasting element of a person's identity.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the two discussion questions from Lesson 27, one at a time. Ask me follow-up questions, and at the end list my grammar mistakes."
- "I will summarize Molly Wright's talk in one minute without notes. Tell me which main points I missed: the brain facts, the five things, serve and return, the games and what happens without connection."
- "Ask me five questions about the reading 'Mirror Stage': who Lacan, Wallon, Tallis and Evans were and what each of them thought. Correct my verb tenses."
- "Read me a definition from the Key language table of Lesson 27. I will say the word and use it in a sentence."
- "Here is my discussion post: [paste]. Check that I answered the question and gave reasons and examples, then list my grammar errors by type."

Read aloud

Read each sentence slowly, then at normal speed. The stressed syllable of the long words is in capitals.

1. Our brains de·VEL·op faster in our early years than at any other time in our lives.
2. Copycat games build i·mag·i·NA·tion and EM·pa·thy.
3. Naming games build vo·CAB·u·lar·y and at·TEN·tion.
4. "Mirror stage" refers to the point in time when infants and TOD·dlers start recognizing their re·FLEC·tions in the mirror.
5. In psy·CHOL·o·gy, there has been a debate about the mirror stage's importance in i·DEN·ti·ty formation.
6. The mirror stage is a phe·NOM·e·non to which I assign two values.

Writing task

In the book, the discussion is a written post for an online class forum. Write your own post on one discussion question from Practice 1 (120 to 180 words): a first sentence that answers the question directly, two reasons, each with an example from the talk, the reading or your own experience, and a final sentence that sums up your opinion. Name the talk and the speaker when you use her ideas, and use at least three words from the Key language table.

Self-editing checklist:

1. Does my first sentence answer the question clearly?
2. Did I give two reasons, each with an example?
3. Did I name my source (the speaker and the title) when I used an idea from the talk?
4. Did I use the simple present for facts and opinions (Children need …) and the simple past for my own past experiences?
5. Does every sentence have a subject and a verb?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it. Then ask your tutor to write two short posts as two classmates, and reply to each one: point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give your opinion on a point they make.

Watch online

- TED talk "How Every Child Can Thrive by Five" by Molly Wright (about 7 minutes): https://www.ted.com/talks/molly_wright_how_every_child_can_thrive_by_five

Answer key

1. Discussion (example answer)

1. Children's brains develop best when adults connect with them, talk to them and play with them, and when they have a healthy home and a community around them. Parents can talk to their baby often, play simple games like peekaboo and naming games, and give their full attention instead of looking at their phones.
2. Technology can be beneficial in some ways: a child can video-call grandparents who live far away, and some apps teach letters and numbers. But it cannot replace people. In the talk, Molly Wright says that adults need to use their devices sometimes, but kids are hardwired to seek out meaningful connections, and not receiving them causes confusion and stress. So I think technology is useful only in small amounts, and adults should use it together with the child.

2. Exercise 1 (book)

1. d (90%). Molly: "by my age, it's almost 90 percent the volume of an adult brain."
2. d (Technology). The five things are connecting, talking, playing, a healthy home and community.
3. a. "That's just a grown-up way of saying connect, talk and play with us."
4. b. "... not receiving them causes confusion and stress."

3. Exercise 2 (book)

1. c. Options a and d are not in the text. Option b is close to Lacan's idea, but the text says other psychologists disagreed with it, so it is not the central idea of the whole text.
2. b. It gives both parts of the central idea: what the mirror stage is (the definition) and the debate about its importance.
3. d. Paragraph 2: by the early 1950s, "he no longer considered the mirror stage as a moment in the life of the infant, but as representing a permanent structure of identity." (Option a is wrong: the age of 15 to 18 months comes from the research in paragraph 1, not from a change in Lacan's idea.)

My notes